

WHAT IS TECHNOLOGY ADDICTION?

While the debate on whether to include technology/internet addiction to the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM) may still be raging in the academic circles, the camp that's pro-inclusion is growing by the day. The symptoms we've mentioned earlier are just some of the factors that might lead to a diagnosis of technology addiction. However, most of us will easily identify with quite a few of the aforementioned symptoms. After all, studies have attested to the



Kids are at greatest risk of addiction

same in the US. And even more so, closer to home. A 2014 study by AT Kearney shows that more Indians were connected to the internet every waking hour than the global average. That's 53%, which puts us in the same league as Brazil, Russia, South Africa and Nigeria. The first world countries are far behind us in this aspect. It's the younger population that's the most active and the highest activity is registered between the ages of 26-35. And a majority of these "addicts" are unmarried and male. And the trend seems to point that kids or 'digital natives' are at a much greater risk of falling prey to technology addiction.

Since this is a mental ailment, there isn't a concrete set of boxes one can check to see if they're addicted. Certain behavioural traits tend to increase the likelihood of addiction. Certain personalities are more prone to seeking their dopamine rush on the internet – especially introverts. Also, those who're under immense pressure at work or home tend to gravitate towards the internet to seek solace. An act which slowly leads to escapism.

IT'S ALL ABOUT CURIOSITY

We humans have this innate trait to be curious. It manifests in many different ways throughout our daily lives. It's what drove us to click on clickbaits, makes babies go berserk around the house, toddlers constantly asking "why?", and in a million other ways. The extent to which we are curious varies from person to person and the context. After all, we might be curious as to what lies at the other end of a train tunnel, but we won't stand bang in the middle of the tracks to assuage our curiosity. We still haven't completely figured out what causes this curiosity, and you could say we're curious about what makes us curious. Curiosity is linked with similar exploratory behaviours. As humans, we have uncertainty and exploring the possible outcomes of a situation puts our mind at ease. Also, there's the inherent possibility that one of these outcomes might be rewarding. Every colonialist power from our history books can attest to that. And so can Vasco da Gama. There's also another theory which states that curiosity motivates one because the end

result can trigger the pleasure centres of the brain. And research indicates that the act of wanting more information directly involves the brain's mesolimbic pathways, the very same that account for dopamine activation. For the uninitiated, Dopamine is an organic chemical synthesized in the brain and kidneys that functions as a neurotransmitter. It's levels are directly proportional to how good we feel. The more Dopamine there is, the better we feel...

Since curiosity is still being explored biologically and psychologically, there aren't any fixed traits to it. We know that curiosity is broadly classified as perceptual curiosity and epistemic curiosity. Perpetual curiosity is what we feel when we are surprised by something. It's also associated with the feeling of an unpleasant outcome. This is what drives us to explore such situations. The other type of curiosity (epistemic

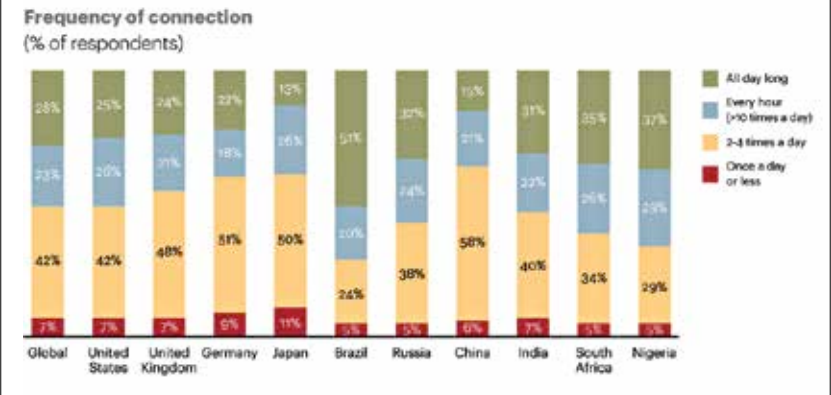


Curiosity defines who we are as a species

curiosity) is the giddiness associated with the anticipation of a reward. Simply put, it's the cause for our thirst for knowledge. When the outcome of a situation is ambiguous, our curiosity remains unsatiated. There are methods of gaining answers which paint a spectrum of possibilities, and there are methods which lead to more concrete answers. The latter approach, obviously, is preferred since it completely satiates our thirst. The very same approach, also involves the use of technological and / or scientific methods.

TECHNOLOGY, THE CURIOSITY ENABLER

Science in itself, and by extension through its applications i.e. technology, is a great enabler. Those trained in the scientific methodologies can theorise,



For most, connectivity is a continuous activity

Source: A.T. Kearney analysis